

Emika S.
Flow

Their feelings rise slowly, inexorably — like water filling a vessel. Every drop brings closer the moment when everything overflows: the silence, the glances, the unspoken words. Nika and Vika both know: one movement, one sound, and the fragile balance will shatter. But what will happen when the flow finally breaks free? And can anything stop it?

This story contains explicit sexual content and is intended for readers 18 and older. Discretion advised.

Prologue

Every other day we went for water — to the utility room, to the sink. The director never ordered delivery, so we walked.

The utility room sat at the end of the corridor, past the fire exit. A small room: a sink, a shelf of cleaning supplies, a fluorescent lamp humming under the ceiling. The door was heavy, with a rubber seal. When it closed, the sounds outside vanished completely. No air conditioner, no phones, no voices from the office. Only the hum of the lamp.

Nika would set her bottle under the tap. I would set mine. We turned the taps at the same moment. There came a quiet gurgle — two identical streams.

And then she would come to me.

Not right away. First she stood by her bottle, watching the water level rise. Then she came to me. Three steps. She stood beside me. Close. So close I could feel the warmth of her arm, though she never touched me.

And she looked into my eyes.

I looked back.

Not a word. Not a movement. Only the murmur of the streams against the plastic. Only the fluorescent light that made her face pale and finely cut. Only her eyes — dark, motionless — in which I could not read a single thought. But I could see that she was thinking **something**. Something she kept silent about.

Five litres take a long time to fill.

The seconds stretched. I counted them by the splashes: every bubble of air, every small strike against the bottom. It seemed to me that if I moved, everything would break. If I said one word, it would break. If I looked away, it would break. We stood in that silence like a room with no doors.

Sometimes she tilted her head, just barely . As if she wanted to see me from another angle. Or was about to speak — and changed her mind. Or was drawn to me, and held that pull back.

I was drawn the same way.
To raise my hand.
To touch her cheek.
To lean in and catch her breath on my lips.
To take the step neither of us had ever taken.

I didn't.
And she didn't.
And the streams went on murmuring.

Once she stood even closer. So close I felt her breath — warm, even — on my cheekbone. Her eyes were ten centimetres from mine. I saw myself reflected in them — tiny, upside down. And something else, besides — something I found no name for then, and find no name for now.

My hand was resting on the edge of the sink.
Then she raised her own — slowly, as if unaware of what she was doing — and took a lock of her hair. She wound that lock around my wrist. Once. Twice. Silently. Without a word.

I watched the dark threads against my skin — fine, almost translucent in the harsh light. I felt every single strand. The pulse beneath them seemed deafening.

And I did not pull my hand away.

Then her bottle filled. The water rose to the neck and the sound changed — denser, duller. I turned to the sink. Closed the tap. Her hair slid from my wrist as I reached for the plastic.

“Done,” I said.

“Done,” she said.

We went out. The door closed. The sounds of the office poured back in — the air conditioner, a keyboard, someone's voice on the phone.

We returned to the office, and everything between us was as it had been before.

Except for one thing: on my wrist, where her hair had lain, the warmth did not fade for several minutes yet.

Chapter 1: Forbidden Fruit

The office smelled of coffee and her perfume — the same one that now filled my dreams at night. I sat at my desk trying to read a report. Letters formed words, words formed sentences, and I didn't understand a single one.

She walked in wearing a plum-colored dress. Tight. New. I noticed immediately — because I was looking at her before I could stop myself.

— Vika, do you mind if I put on some music?

I nodded.

Jazz. Slow. A saxophone held a note, and it hung in the air like a thread.

Nika didn't sit down. She stood by the window, back to me, and began unfastening the buttons at her wrists. One. Two. The fabric loosened, and the dress shifted on her left shoulder. Skin appeared — tanned, smooth — and a thin strap of a black bra.

She turned to me sideways. The strap lay on her collarbone. Her shoulder was completely bare. I could see the hollow beneath it, the shadow of the strap on her skin.

— God, it's stuffy, she said.

She took a step toward me. One. Her knee almost touched my desk. I could feel warmth from her body — at arm's length.

— Aren't you hot?

I didn't answer. Couldn't. Because if I opened my mouth — I don't know what would have come out.

Her fingers touched my wrist. Just settled — fingertips on skin, right where the pulse is. I flinched. Not pulling away. From the impossibility of pulling away. Anatomy

— Vika, she said quietly. — You want this.

I didn't answer.

Because she was right.

Her fingers slid along my wrist — up, two centimeters. The skin burned where she'd touched it. I could feel every ridge of her fingertip, every millimeter.

And then — a sound. The door.

Her hand withdrew. She stepped back — quickly, but not sharply. Fixed her shoulder, pulled up the dress. To me — a mask, as if nothing had happened. To the door — a smile.

I sat there. On my wrist — a spot of warmth slowly cooling.

Chapter 2: Playing with Fire

Afternoon silence. The sun blazed through the windows, and the AC barely kept up, pushing warm air through the office. I tried to focus on my screen, but my thoughts kept circling back to yesterday — her leg on the chair, the hem she'd lifted, the stray hairs I shouldn't have seen. Between my legs, warmth pulsed like an echo.

— It's still hot, Nika said. — Let's go to the window. Cool off.

She stood first. I hesitated a second — then followed her. Like yesterday. Like the day before.

By the window stood a desk, and in front of it — a different chair. Nika positioned herself to the right of it, facing the window. Light flooded her from behind, and I could only see her silhouette — shoulders, waist, hips. The air from the AC blew from above, lifting strands of her hair.

She turned to me. I stepped up beside her.

— Still hot, she repeated, and put her left foot on the chair.

My eyes slid down. The hem of her dress had risen, exposing her thigh — smooth, lightly tanned. She noticed me looking and slowly pulled the hem higher. I knew I should look away. Couldn't.

— I'll fan myself, she said and began waving the hem like a fan. — Better. Cooler.

And I saw them. Pink panties. Lace, thin elastic, a delicate color — not bright, something muted. They sat on her as if they were part of her skin.

I looked for a second. Two. Three. Or longer — I didn't count.

— Notice the new ones? she asked. No embarrassment in her voice. Just curiosity. — Do you think they suit me?

— Y-yes, I said. My throat was dry.

— I bought them specially. In the lingerie section. Pretty, right?

She pulled the fabric tighter on her thigh, turned slightly. The pink lace stretched. I could see every cell of the pattern.

— Do you like them? she repeated.

— Yes.

— Have you ever bought something like that?

I looked away. My face was burning.

— No.

— Maybe we could go? This weekend? Get you some too. Want to?

I looked at her. She was watching me — directly, calmly, as if asking if I wanted coffee.

— I can't, I said.

— Do you have a date?

— No.

— With a girl?

I turned to the window. — No. Not a date.

She stepped closer. From the left. I felt her nearby — warmth, scent, something fruity.

— The cool air is better here, she said.

Then she raised her arms and stretched. The shirt pulled tight across her chest, and I saw — two round shapes, nipples showing through the fabric. I looked away sharply.

— Where are you going? she asked.

— I need to find more options for the project.

I sat at the computer. My back burned — I knew she was watching me leave.

Chapter 3: A LOCK OF HAIR

It was around three. The office was quiet — everyone at their monitors, keyboards tapping evenly, like raindrops on a roof.

I was looking at a layout. Nika beside me — at her own screen. My hand lay on the desk between us — an ordinary thing, the way it always was.

Then I felt it.

Not a touch. Not a breeze from the air conditioner. Something else entirely — light, weightless, like breath. A lock of Nika's hair. It lay on my wrist — simply lay there, its tip against my skin, and I could not understand when it had arrived. A second ago it had not been there.

I did not move.

Nika did not move either. She looked at her monitor. She typed. An utterly ordinary young woman doing utterly ordinary work. Except that her lock of hair lay on my skin, and from that place a warmth spread up my arm — thin, fine, like the note of a tuning fork you hear only from the inside.

One second.

Ten seconds.

I glanced at the colleagues at the far end of the room. Sergey — in his headphones. Marina — drinking coffee, eyes on her phone. No one was turned toward us.

Half a minute.

The lock of hair lay on. The skin beneath it burned — not painfully, not hotly — it simply **burned**, the way a candle burns in a dark room: quietly, evenly, inevitably. I felt every millimetre of that touch — a weight barely perceptible, a pressure almost imaginary, and yet real. As real as my pulse, which I could now hear in my wrist — right there, beneath the lock of hair.

A minute.

Olga from accounting rose from her desk. I went still. She walked past us to the water cooler — didn't look, didn't turn her head. Poured herself some water. Left.

The lock of hair was not withdrawn.

My breathing grew shallow. I was afraid my chest would rise too visibly, that someone would see something was wrong with me. But I kept looking at my monitor. Kept sitting there. As usual.

A minute and a half.

Somewhere a phone rang. Someone laughed. The printer began to run — a long document, the rustle of pages.

The lock of hair lay on.

I thought: if someone turned around now, what would they see? Two colleagues. Side by side. Working. A lock of hair on a wrist — what is that? Nothing. Absolutely nothing. It means nothing. It's just... hair.

But I knew it meant everything.

Two minutes.

Nika turned her head toward me — slowly, as if she wanted to ask something about the layout. She looked into my eyes. And I saw it — she knew. She was reading every breath I took. She felt what was happening beneath her lock of hair as precisely as I felt it.

Her eyes were dark. Calm on the surface. And not calm at all underneath.

She turned back to her monitor.

Another ten seconds.

And the lock of hair was gone. It simply vanished — she shifted slightly, and the lock of hair slid from my skin, leaving only the absence of its warmth, which I felt more keenly than the warmth itself.

I looked at my wrist. No mark. But I knew that this small patch of skin would remember. Would remember forever.

“The indent is wrong here,” Nika said in an ordinary voice, nodding at my screen.

“Yes, I see,” I said in an ordinary voice.

And we went on working.

Every time, something new.

And on the days when she did nothing, it was worse.

I would come to work and wait. Every movement of hers — whether she turned, or leaned over, or fell into thought — I read as a signal.

By lunchtime my nerves were stretched to their limit. By evening they would let go, and I would be angry with myself for the disappointment.

For three weeks she went on like this. One small step, a pause. One small step, a pause.